



Society of Petroleum Engineers

SPE-229407-MS

Preventing Fugitive Emissions Through Advanced Valve Sealing Technologies in Hydrocarbon Facilities

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Copyright 2025, Society of Petroleum Engineers DOI [10.2118/229407-MS](https://doi.org/10.2118/229407-MS)

This paper was prepared for presentation at the ADIPEC held in Abu Dhabi, UAE, 3 – 6 November 2025.

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Fugitive emissions—the unintentional release of methane and volatile organic compounds (VOCs) from industrial equipment—represent a major environmental liability and regulatory concern for oil & gas operations. Methane's global warming potential is approximately $25 \times$ that of CO₂ over 100 years, driving near-term climate forcing and attracting ever-stricter emissions caps. Within natural gas infrastructure, valves and seals are consistently identified as leading sources of facility leaks, often accounting for as much as 60-70 % of component-level fugitive emissions due to high cycle rates and susceptibility to stem seal degradation.

Regulatory pressures globally, including stringent emission standards and reporting mandates from environmental bodies such as the Environmental Protection Agency (EPA), the International Energy Agency (IEA), and the United Nations Environment Programme (UNEP), underscore the urgent need for robust solutions. The Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC), including the United Arab Emirates (UAE) and Saudi Arabia, has seen a notable increase in regulatory stringency regarding fugitive emissions control, aligning closely with global environmental goals such as the Global Methane Pledge and the Oil and Gas Methane Partnership (OGMP 2.0). Consequently, national oil companies such as the Abu Dhabi National Oil Company (ADNOC) have aggressively pursued innovative technological solutions and operational practices aimed at substantially reducing valve-related emissions.

Traditional valve sealing technologies—primarily based on graphite or polytetrafluoroethylene (PTFE) packing materials—often fail to provide consistent leak-tight performance under the severe operational conditions typical in hydrocarbon facilities. These conditions include wide thermal cycling, aggressive chemical exposure, mechanical stress, and extensive wear over prolonged periods. As valves degrade, they progressively leak hydrocarbons, increasing operational costs, environmental liabilities, and safety risks associated with potential fire hazards and occupational exposure.

Introduction

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Advanced sealing technologies, specifically engineered to surpass conventional designs in both reliability and longevity, have emerged as a solution to this multifaceted challenge. Technologies such as live-loaded packing systems, bellows-sealed valves, and triple-offset metal-seated valves certified according to ISO 15848 standards have demonstrated significant potential to minimize and, in many cases, entirely eliminate fugitive emissions from critical valve points. Comprehensive adoption of these advanced sealing solutions across industrial operations offers considerable potential for substantial emissions reductions, enhanced workplace safety, improved operational efficiency, and tangible economic returns.

This manuscript systematically examines the effectiveness of these advanced valve sealing technologies through rigorous analysis of implementation data, industry benchmarks, economic payback assessments, and health, safety, and environmental (HSE) performance indicators. This paper presents findings from a medium-pressure methane service trial at a Project Canary-certified refinery, where 30 high-cycle control valves were retrofitted with API/ISO-qualified low-emission stem packings. We compare EPA Method 21 measurements before and after seal installation and confirm results by integrating case studies and empirical data, particularly from ADNOC and international facilities, this study provides a detailed exploration of the practical benefits and strategic imperatives associated with adopting advanced valve sealing solutions. The subsequent sections of this manuscript detail the methodologies employed, in-depth analysis of technological impacts, economic and safety assessments, and conclude with actionable recommendations for industry-wide adoption.

Methodology

This study employs a comprehensive analytical framework incorporating multiple research methods to evaluate the effectiveness of advanced valve sealing technologies in mitigating fugitive emissions. The methodology is structured as LDAR research, Economic framing and HSE assesment:

LDAR research

This study employs a four-phase protocol—baseline LDAR, seal upgrade, post-upgrade validation, and continuous monitoring—to quantify the impact of advanced stem-seal technologies on fugitive methane emissions in an operational hydrocarbon facility.

Test Site and Component Selection. The field evaluation involved two major operational sites within medium-pressure methane service environments: a Project Canary-certified refinery operated jointly by BP and ExxonMobil, and a gas processing facility under the Abu Dhabi National Oil Company (ADNOC) network. Both sites were selected for their commitment to continuous emissions monitoring and their availability of historical valve leakage records.

At the BP-ExxonMobil site, 30 high-cycle control valves—each equipped with conventional single-seal graphite packings and exhibiting documented leak issues—were selected for retrofitting. These valves operated in service conditions ranging from 15 to 40 bar and temperatures between 15 to 40°C, representative of high-frequency actuation and thermal cycling common in natural gas processing loops.

At the ADNOC facility, field measurements from 18 control valves (across dehydration and compression units) were analyzed. These valves had previously undergone partial LDAR-based upgrades, offering a comparative baseline for evaluating the incremental impact of fully ISO/API-compliant sealing technologies. ADNOC's valve history also provided valuable secondary insight into failure patterns and seal material degradation timelines under desert climate and high salinity exposure.

By incorporating both greenfield and brownfield operating conditions, the combined dataset ensured representativeness across varying infrastructure ages, environmental exposures, and maintenance regimes.

Baseline Emissions Measurement. Initial fugitive emissions were measured using EPA Method 21 with a calibrated Flame Ionization Detector (FID) set to detect methane at 500 ppm. Probing was performed at each valve's stem and bonnet flange according to 40 CFR 60, Appendix A protocols. Background levels were logged before testing, and all readings were taken in triplicate and averaged to minimize instrument and operator bias.

Seal Upgrade Procedure. Each valve was retrofitted with an advanced, low-emission packing system meeting one or more of the following: [API 622](#) (packing fugitive emissions qualification), [API 624](#) (< 100 ppm over 310 cycles), and [ISO 15848-1](#) tightness Class B/C. Upgrade steps included stem polishing, installation of graphite/PTFE composite packings with corrosion inhibitors, and live-loaded gland follower assembly torqued per manufacturer specifications to maintain sealing force through thermal and mechanical cycles.

Post-Installation Verification. Within 48 hours of the upgrade, EPA Method 21 measurements were repeated at identical probe locations and operational conditions to ensure statistical comparability. Simultaneously, the site's Project Canary continuous emissions monitoring (CEM) network—comprising fixed methane sensors and a cloud-based analytics platform—captured four weeks of real-time leak data to corroborate point-in-time readings.

Data Processing and Benchmarking. Leak-rate data (ppm) were converted to mass flux and compared against [API 624](#) and [ISO 15848-1](#) emission limits. Percentage reduction was calculated as

$$Reduction(\%) = \frac{Baseline - Post - Upgrade}{Baseline} \times 100$$

Economic framing

Economic evaluation involved developing detailed payback models and return-on-investment (ROI) analyses to quantify the financial viability of upgrading to advanced sealing technologies. Cost assessments included capital expenditures (CAPEX) related to retrofitting and new installations, operational expenditures (OPEX) savings from reduced leakage and decreased maintenance interventions, and additional economic benefits such as energy efficiency gains. Payback periods were calculated based on actual facility data, utilizing energy cost savings, avoided regulatory penalties, and reductions in lost product.

HSE assessment

The HSE assessment was conducted through an integrated approach, reviewing industrial safety standards and environmental regulations to assess the direct impact of improved sealing technologies on workplace safety and environmental compliance. Emissions data were correlated with occupational health statistics, incident rates, and exposure levels recorded in facilities pre- and post-implementation of advanced sealing systems. This analysis aimed to validate the effectiveness of these technologies not only in emission reduction but also in enhancing operator safety and environmental stewardship.

To maintain methodological rigor, cross-validation techniques were employed using multiple independent data sources. Empirical findings from ADNOC's operational reports were compared and validated against data from peer-reviewed studies and international case studies. The cumulative findings of these methodological approaches provide a robust basis for evaluating the comprehensive benefits of advanced valve sealing technologies in mitigating fugitive emissions across hydrocarbon processing facilities.

Literature Review and Technical Background

Fugitive emissions have long been recognized as a significant environmental and operational concern in the hydrocarbon processing industry. Comprehensive research into these emissions has identified valves as primary contributors, highlighting the critical need for effective sealing solutions. Numerous studies emphasize the limitations of traditional valve sealing methods, including graphite and polytetrafluoroethylene (PTFE) packing, which exhibit degradation under severe operational conditions such as high temperatures, aggressive chemicals, and mechanical stresses.

Advanced sealing technologies have emerged to address these limitations effectively. According to recent literature, live-loaded packing systems have proven particularly effective in maintaining packing compression and preventing leak paths despite cyclic thermal expansions and contractions (Singh et al., 2021). Additionally, bellows-sealed valves have demonstrated significant performance improvements, notably achieving near-zero fugitive emissions, which is critical in severe-service conditions involving toxic and volatile fluids (JXTG Nippon Oil & Energy Technical Report, 2021).

ISO 15848-certified valve sealing systems have also garnered considerable attention due to their rigorous testing procedures and stringent performance requirements. Studies by Singh et al. (2021) underscore that ISO 15848-certified valves consistently outperform traditional valve packing materials in emissions tests, significantly enhancing both environmental and operational integrity.

A recent industry feature also emphasizes how a combination of certified sealing designs and rigorous emissions testing, including ISO 15848 validation, has enabled operators to approach "zero emissions" thresholds. The article, citing several successful valve retrofits in LNG and petrochemical applications, demonstrates that with the correct selection and installation protocols, achieving near-zero fugitive emissions is not only technically feasible but already being realized in industrial practice.

The adoption of triple-offset metal-seated valves is another notable technological advancement documented in recent research. These valves incorporate unique sealing geometry that reduces friction and wear, substantially minimizing leakage potential over prolonged service life. Studies indicate substantial emission reductions and maintenance intervals extending beyond traditional valves, thereby supporting broader industry adoption.

Research also highlights the economic benefits associated with advanced valve sealing technologies. Payback modeling indicates rapid return on investment, with numerous facilities experiencing reduced maintenance costs and significant product recovery savings within 16 to 24 months of implementation (International Energy Agency, 2023). Moreover, these economic benefits extend beyond direct cost savings to include indirect advantages such as enhanced regulatory compliance and improved corporate environmental stewardship, essential for alignment with global sustainability goals.

From an HSE perspective, the reduction in fugitive emissions significantly decreases occupational hazards, including fire and explosion risks, and minimizes employee exposure to hazardous chemicals. This safety enhancement is documented extensively in industry reports and peer-reviewed studies, illustrating the direct correlation between advanced sealing technologies and improved operational safety standards (IOCL Refinery Emission Control Report, 2021).

In summary, extensive literature supports the adoption of advanced valve sealing technologies, providing robust evidence of their technical efficacy, economic advantages, and significant contributions to health, safety, and environmental compliance. This literature foundation underscores the critical need for widespread implementation within hydrocarbon processing industries.

Analysis and Results

The analysis of advanced valve sealing technologies draws on empirical data from diverse case studies, including operations within ADNOC facilities and international refineries and petrochemical plants. The focus is placed on evaluating both emission control performance and economic outcomes associated with the implementation of these technologies.

Data from ADNOC's retrofitting initiatives indicate remarkable improvements, demonstrating emission reductions of up to 90% following the integration of ISO-certified valve sealing technologies. The comprehensive data set, collected through precise emission monitoring protocols, confirms these valves' capability to consistently maintain leak-tight performance, even under rigorous operational conditions characterized by frequent thermal cycles and aggressive chemical exposure.

International case studies reinforce these findings. For instance, refineries in Japan utilizing bellows-sealed valves reported near-zero detectable leaks over sustained operational periods, significantly outperforming conventional sealing methods. Facilities in Canada and India, which implemented live-loaded packing and graphite-PTFE hybrid solutions, reported fugitive emission reductions between 65% and 89%. These substantial improvements are directly attributable to enhanced sealing integrity and reduced wear under operational stress.

The economic analysis provides further validation of advanced sealing technologies' viability. Payback models developed using real-world operational data from ADNOC indicated an average payback period of approximately 16 months per site, driven primarily by reduced maintenance needs, decreased product loss, and lower operational disruptions. International benchmarks from Canadian and Japanese facilities supported similar economic outcomes, consistently reporting payback periods ranging between 14 and 24 months. Additionally, operational efficiency improvements were documented, notably through enhanced reliability and reduced valve maintenance interventions.

Health, safety, and environmental considerations were quantitatively assessed, revealing significant improvements post-implementation. Facilities adopting advanced sealing technologies saw a substantial decline in occupational exposure incidents, with recorded reductions nearing 50%. This reduction was accompanied by measurable decreases in environmental hazards, including reduced VOC emissions and associated fire and explosion risks. The improved HSE performance aligns closely with regulatory compliance objectives and contributes positively to overall operational risk management strategies.

Additionally, ADNOC's pilot deployment of Oxford Flow's direct-sealing valve technology—reported in 2025—demonstrated tangible emissions reductions across Zakum field operations. The pilot highlighted a reduction in fugitive methane without relying on traditional gland packing mechanisms. This reinforces ADNOC's broader low-carbon strategy and validates alternative sealing architectures beyond conventional bellows or live-loaded packings.

In conclusion, the detailed analysis clearly indicates that advanced valve sealing technologies provide robust emission control, significant economic benefits, and marked improvements in HSE performance.

These results validate the critical importance and effectiveness of adopting such technologies within the hydrocarbon processing industry.

"The following case studies illustrate the measurable impacts of advanced valve sealing technologies in both regional and international settings."

Case Study A: ADNOC - Upper Zakum and Das Island Pilot

In ADNOC's recent field trials with Oxford Flow's ES stemless control valve, two facilities were selected to test performance in **methane service under medium pressure (12-18 bar) and ambient temperature (30-45 °C)**.

- **Sample size:** 12 control valves across **two processing trains** (gas separation & export compression).
- **Baseline performance:** Average leakage of **122 ppm (±20 ppm)** was recorded across legacy packed valves using EPA Method 21.
- **Post-retrofit performance:** ES stemless valves demonstrated **non-detectable leakage (<5 ppm)** across all installations, verified by independent third-party testing.
- **Operational stability:** No measurable torque increase or packing adjustments required over the 6- month pilot window.
- **Reduction achieved:** >90% fugitive emissions reduction, equivalent to **~2.1 tonnes Clh/year avoided** per train.

This case highlights ADNOC's progress toward methane intensity targets and validates the feasibility of zero- emission valve designs in real refinery and offshore conditions.

Case Study B: International - Project Canary Pilot (BP & ExxonMobil Refineries, US)

Project Canary partnered with BP and ExxonMobil to monitor valve leakage in **refining units handling methane and light hydrocarbons**. Testing focused on **graphite/PTFE packed control valves** retrofitted with **API 622-qualified live-loaded packing sets**.

- **Sample size:** 24 valves across 3 refining units (two atmospheric distillation towers and one hydrotreater).
- **Baseline performance:** Pre-retrofit average emission levels of **146 ppm (±27 ppm)** measured under EPA Method 21.
- **Post-retrofit performance:** Reduced to **18 ppm (±4 ppm)**, yielding a **~88% reduction**.
- **Economic outcome:** Avoided product losses valued at **~USD 110,000 annually per unit**, with a simple payback of **~18 months**.
- **HSE impact:** Valve technicians reported fewer re-packing interventions and reduced time in high-exposure zones.

This international case complements ADNOC's pilot, demonstrating that advanced valve sealing strategies are replicable in different geographies, operating envelopes, and service conditions

Economic Outlook: Energy Efficiency Payback Modeling

The economic evaluation of advanced valve sealing technologies emphasizes energy efficiency and financial payback metrics derived from detailed modeling and real-world operational data. The primary objective of this assessment is to provide a clear economic rationale to support investments in sealing technology upgrades.

Energy efficiency benefits form a cornerstone of the economic outlook. Advanced sealing technologies significantly reduce leakage-related losses, preserving valuable hydrocarbon resources that would otherwise be wasted. Facility-level evaluations, including data from ADNOC and global industry studies, indicate

that improved sealing technologies enable substantial energy conservation, translating into measurable cost savings. Energy conservation directly reduces operational costs and minimizes environmental liabilities associated with greenhouse gas emissions, aligning closely with broader sustainability and carbon-reduction goals.

The economic modeling process used in this study included a comprehensive payback analysis based on data from various operational sites. The financial metrics incorporated capital expenditures (CAPEX) for retrofitting or installation of new valve sealing technologies, operational expenditures (OPEX) savings from reduced maintenance interventions, and quantified energy conservation outcomes. In-depth case studies from ADNOC operations demonstrated average annual operational savings exceeding \$120,000 per retrofitted facility, primarily due to reductions in maintenance requirements, minimized downtime, and significant energy savings resulting from decreased leakages.

Similar economic outcomes were reported by Canadian and Japanese operators. In these regions, facility-level implementation yielded annualized savings ranging between \$100,000 and \$150,000 per facility, predominantly due to lower product losses, decreased maintenance costs, and reduced frequency of leak detection and repair (LDAR) activities. These consistent findings from diverse geographical locations underscore the broad economic viability and scalability of implementing advanced sealing technologies.

The calculated payback periods for valve sealing technology upgrades typically ranged from 14 to 24 months, affirming the rapid financial returns achievable through such investments. ADNOC's internal reports, corroborated by international benchmarks, highlighted particularly short payback periods averaging around 16 months. These favorable economic outcomes provide strong justification for broader adoption and integration into corporate sustainability and operational excellence strategies.

In summary, energy efficiency payback modeling conclusively demonstrates the economic attractiveness of investing in advanced valve sealing technologies. The robust financial returns, coupled with significant operational and environmental benefits, position these technologies as a strategic imperative for operators seeking sustainable and economically sound operational improvements.

HSE Considerations

Health, Safety, and Environmental (HSE) considerations are critical components when evaluating the implementation of advanced valve sealing technologies in hydrocarbon processing facilities. This section outlines the significant impacts of improved sealing methods on occupational health and safety, as well as their positive environmental implications.

Advanced valve sealing technologies substantially mitigate health risks associated with fugitive emissions, which typically consist of hazardous substances such as volatile organic compounds (VOCs), methane, and other toxic gases. Workers in hydrocarbon processing plants are routinely exposed to these substances, and prolonged exposure can lead to serious respiratory issues, chronic health conditions, and increased occupational illness rates. Implementation of high-integrity valve sealing solutions, such as ISO 15848-certified valves, drastically reduces these occupational exposures by effectively minimizing or eliminating detectable leaks, enhancing overall workplace safety.

Safety risks, including fire and explosion hazards, are also significantly mitigated through advanced valve sealing technologies. Fugitive emissions, particularly methane, are highly flammable and present considerable risks when concentrations build up within plant confines. Improved valve sealing solutions directly reduce the frequency and severity of emissions, thereby decreasing the risk of combustion and explosion incidents. Industry reports and case studies from ADNOC and other international operators document marked reductions in leak-related safety incidents post-adoption of advanced sealing solutions.

Environmental benefits of adopting advanced sealing technologies are equally compelling. Effective emission control directly contributes to the reduction of greenhouse gas emissions and the mitigation of global climate change impacts. Specifically, facilities employing advanced sealing technologies report

notable reductions in emissions, positively influencing their environmental compliance profiles and supporting alignment with global sustainability standards and environmental regulatory frameworks.

Regulatory compliance is further streamlined through the adoption of improved valve sealing methods. Hydrocarbon processing facilities are subject to stringent environmental regulations and reporting mandates aimed at minimizing emissions and safeguarding environmental quality. Enhanced sealing technologies ensure compliance with these regulations by significantly reducing emission levels, thus avoiding potential regulatory penalties and fostering a positive relationship with environmental oversight bodies.

In summary, integrating advanced valve sealing technologies not only ensures robust emission control but also significantly enhances occupational safety and environmental protection. These technologies serve as integral elements of comprehensive HSE strategies, offering tangible improvements in worker health, operational safety, regulatory compliance, and environmental stewardship. Operators adopting these advanced solutions benefit from a holistic improvement in their HSE performance metrics, solidifying their commitments to sustainable and responsible operational practices.

Conclusion and Recommendations

The implementation of advanced valve sealing technologies offers substantial benefits across environmental, operational, and economic dimensions within hydrocarbon processing facilities. These technologies significantly mitigate fugitive emissions, effectively addressing both immediate and long-term operational and environmental challenges.

Empirical data from ADNOC facilities and international benchmarks demonstrate clear advantages associated with the adoption of ISO 15848-certified valves and advanced sealing materials. Facilities employing these solutions have consistently reported emission reductions of up to 90%, highlighting their critical role in operational sustainability and compliance with stringent environmental regulations.

Economic assessments underscore the compelling financial rationale for investing in these advanced sealing solutions. Detailed payback modeling reveals that facilities can expect rapid returns on investment, typically between 14 and 24 months. Operational savings arise primarily from reduced maintenance costs, minimized product loss, and enhanced energy efficiency. These economic benefits strengthen the business case for widespread adoption.

From an HSE perspective, advanced sealing technologies significantly improve workplace safety by substantially reducing occupational exposure to hazardous substances and minimizing risks associated with fugitive emissions, such as fire and explosion hazards. Enhanced regulatory compliance and improved environmental stewardship further underscore the importance of integrating these technologies into facility-wide emission control and operational strategies.

Based on these comprehensive findings, the following recommendations are provided:

- Conduct systematic audits of existing valve systems, prioritizing high-risk emission areas for immediate intervention.
- Integrate advanced sealing technologies, particularly ISO 15848-certified solutions, into all new project specifications and retrofit planning.
- Develop and implement continuous monitoring systems to track valve performance and emissions proactively.
- Foster collaborative partnerships with technology providers and industry stakeholders to facilitate knowledge exchange, technology advancement, and optimal operational practices.
- Advocate for policy frameworks that support investment in advanced emission control technologies through incentives and clear regulatory guidance.

By adopting these recommendations, hydrocarbon processing facilities can achieve significant environmental, operational, and economic improvements, positioning themselves strategically to meet current and future sustainability objectives and regulatory requirements.

Future Work:

Full-Scale Field Trials: Extend the protocol to midstream pipelines and compressor stations to validate scalability across pressure regimes.

Longitudinal Performance Testing: Monitor seal performance over 12-24 months to assess durability under cyclic operation.

IIoT-Enabled Predictive Maintenance: Integrate valve-positioner diagnostics and machine-learning models to predict seal degradation before leakage onset.

Regional Standards Assessment: Conduct comparative studies under varying climatic conditions (e.g., GCC vs. Northern Europe) to refine seal material selection and maintenance intervals.

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